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RESEARCH ARTICLE

The Affective Politics of Police Mediation: *Renqing*, Resistance and Governance in Grassroots China

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Abstract

This article examines how "human affect" (*renqing*) – the interplay of affect, moral obligation and social legitimacy – operates as both a mechanism of governance and a site of contestation in police mediation in contemporary China. Drawing on six months of ethnographic fieldwork in two police stations in Zhejiang province, I conceptualize *renqing* as an affective grammar: a system of emotional expression and recognition that structures interaction across interpersonal and institutional settings. The party-state's revival of the Fengqiao model has transformed *renqing* from a micro-political norm into an institutionalized instrument of affective governance. Mediation formalizes affect through contracts, scripted performances and service quotas, stratifying emotional legitimacy along lines of class, gender and migration. The article theorizes affective autonomy as participants' resistance through silence, withdrawal or alternative alignments. It complicates portrayals of policing as purely coercive, highlighting the emotional labour and limits of grassroots governance.

摘要

本文探讨了"人情" – 情感、道德义务与社会合法性交织的机制 – 如何在当代中国的警务调解中同时作为治理的工具和争议的场域。基于在浙江省两个派出所为期六个月的民族志田野工作， 文章将人情概念化为一种"情感语法"， 即一种结构化人际与制度性互动的情感表达与承认体系。随着党国对"枫桥经验"的复兴， 人情从一种微观政治规范转变为制度化的情感治理工具。调解通过合同、表演化脚本和服务指标将情感形式化， 并沿着阶级、性别和流动等社会分层界限来分配情感合法性。本文进一步提出"情感自主性"的分析框架， 用以理解当事人通过沉默、退缩或另行结盟等方式对警务调解的抵抗。这一分析复杂化了将警务单纯理解为强制性的看法， 凸显了基层治理中的情感劳动及其局限性。

Keywords: affect; affective governance; autonomy; Fengqiao model; grassroots resistance; police mediation

关键词: 情感; 自主性; 情感治理; 警务调解; 基层抵抗; 枫桥经验

The mediation room smelled of burning cigarettes. The air conditioning was set to 19 degrees, yet the three people to my right were sweating profusely. No one was speaking, but the couple on the bamboo bench stared intently at the young man smoking across from them. To my left, Old Wang, the mediator, flipped through what appeared to be blank sheets of paper. The case was unusual: the young man had been caught filming a woman in the shower – an administrative offence typically handled through formal punishment.[1] But the woman insisted on mediation, seeking direct

1 According to Chinese law, this act is classified not as sexual assault but as an invasion of privacy under the Law on Penalties for Administration of Public Security – an administrative offence typically punishable by up to five days' detention and

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compensation rather than a fine paid to the state. After hours of tense negotiation, they settled on 2,500 yuan, five times the legal maximum. Later, Old Wang explained his decision: "I should have just let the law punish him," he sighed. "But the law has no 'flavour of human affect' (*renqingwei* 人情味) and cannot give the woman what she wanted."

Old Wang's decision to mediate beyond the legal bounds reveals how grassroots justice is negotiated in contemporary China. His remark that "the law has no *renqingwei*" highlights the law's failure to accommodate affective dimensions of harm and repair. This article examines the role of "human affect" (*renqing* 人情), composed of *ren* 人 (person) and *qing* 情 (affect), which organizes emotional expression, exchange and obligation, linking affect to legitimacy across interpersonal and institutional contexts. In the everyday, people negotiate the competing demands of *renqing* and "reason" (*li* 理),[2] a tension encapsulated in the saying "to harmonize affect and reason" (*heqing heli* 合情合理).[3] In state governance, this tension intensifies as affective scripts are mobilized to resolve disputes and uphold order.

This logic has been formally institutionalized in the party-state's revival of the Fengqiao experience (*Fengqiao jingyan* 枫桥经验), which in recent years has been promoted as a model for "unblocking and standardizing channels for public expression of demands" (*changtong he guifan qunzhong suqiu biaoda* 畅通和规范群众诉求表达) and resolving conflicts at the grassroots.[4] Instead of relying solely on coercion, local governments now outsource mediation work to affective experts who translate bureaucratic objectives into emotionally resonant outcomes.

This article conceptualizes *renqing* as an *affective grammar*: a structured system of emotional expression and recognition that organizes interaction within informal and institutional settings. Drawing on six months of ethnographic fieldwork conducted in 2023 in two police stations in A city, Zhejiang, I show how the state has transformed *renqing* from a micro-political practice into a tool of affective governance. Once circulating through cycles of gifting and obligation, forming "a micro-level network of power without a central subject,"[5] *renqing* is now formalized through contractual arrangements. This institutionalization stratifies access to emotional legitimacy, privileging those embedded in local networks while marginalizing migrants, rural residents and women. I also introduce the concept of *affective autonomy* to capture how participants resist these emotional scripts through silence, withdrawal or alternative affective alignments. Highlighting the quiet mechanisms of affective control and the subtle refusals that expose their limits, this analysis challenges portrayals of Chinese policing as purely coercive or spectacularly violent.

By bridging sociological and anthropological work on *renqing*[6] with affect theory and feminist scholarship on emotional regimes, moral subjectivity and embodied governance,[7] I move beyond accounts that frame China's "stability maintenance" (*weiwen* 维稳) system solely in terms of surveillance or coercion.[8] Affect, in this framework, is both regulated and relational: shaped by "emotional regimes" that define which feelings are politically permissible,[9] and by the way emotions "stick" to

a fine under 500 yuan, payable to the state. Such offences occupy a legal grey zone: quasi-criminal violations processed through simplified, discretionary procedures, with classification based on severity.

2 Liu 2018.

3 Zhang 2006; Martin 2019.

4 See "Zhonggong zhongyang guanyu jianchi he wanshan Zhongguo tese shehuizhuyi zhidu – tuijin guojia zhili tixi he zhili nengli xiandaihua ruogan zhongda wenti de jueding" (Decision of the CCP Central Committee on some major issues concerning upholding and improving the socialist system with Chinese characteristics and advancing the modernization of China's system and capacity for governance), issued 5 November 2019. Full text available at https://www.gov.cn/zhengce/2019-11/05/content_5449023.htm.

5 Chen 2019, 52.

6 Yan 1996a; 1996b; Hwang 1987; Kipnis 1997.

7 Hochschild 1979; Reddy 2001; Ahmed 2004; Berlant 2011.

8 Biddulph 2015.

9 Reddy 2001, 128.

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bodies and accumulate meaning as they circulate.[10] I show how affective labour, "cultural intimacy"[11] and moral scripts are mobilized to uphold political order, often under the guise of tradition and care. In doing so, the article contributes to current debates on the role of affect in authoritarian governance, the commodification of care and the strategic deployment of cultural forms in contemporary China.

The article unfolds in three parts. First, it provides a genealogy of the Fengqiao model's shift from Maoist emotion work to institutionalized affect management. This is followed by an ethnographic analysis of *renqing* as affective grammar in the mediation room. The third part offers a theorization of affective autonomy as resistance within compulsory participation.

From Mass Line to Institutionalized Mediation

The Fengqiao experience, or Fengqiao model, emerged during the "socialist education" campaign (1962–1966) in Zhejiang province as the Party sought to identify "class enemies" while avoiding the uncontrolled violence of earlier campaigns. It operationalized mass line principles through nonviolent, community-based "reasoned struggles," during which cadres mobilized residents to persuade and surveil their neighbours.[12] This method of resolving "contradictions among the people" proved so effective that Mao Zedong 毛泽东 endorsed it in 1963 as a model of grassroots governance.[13]

Rather than a judicial or mediation practice, Fengqiao functioned as a policing discourse grounded in Maoist principles of proactive control and mass-line engagement.[14] Although it receded from national discourse during the early reform era, the model was locally revived in the 1990s as a cost-effective strategy for dispute resolution and petition prevention and was formally reintroduced by the Ministry of Public Security as part of a broader push for pre-emptive, non-escalatory governance.[15] Under Xi Jinping 习近平, it has since been reframed as a model of "modernized" community governance. The continuity of Fengqiao across political eras illustrates how emotional and relational scripts have been retooled to serve shifting governance logics. This evolving framework laid the foundation for affective governance in which *renqing* would be institutionalized not through revolutionary mobilization but through state-contracted emotional labour embedded in grassroots bureaucracies.[16]

In cities like A, local governments purchase mediation through a bidding process called "purchase of services" (*goumai fuwu* 购买服务), formalizing dispute resolution as performance-based service work. The incorporation of mediation as a bureaucratic tool reflects a wider shift towards "a mass line concept without the masses."[17] The affective infrastructure of governance is thus not abandoned but repurposed. Composed of institutional outsourcing, scripted performances of harmony and routinized displays of emotional propriety, it now relies on calibrated affective labour to sustain social cohesion, displacing the earlier model of mass participation.

From Mobilization to Management: Mediation and the Politics of Affect

The shift from mobilizing the masses to employing service providers reflects a fundamental transformation in how the state governs through affect. Under Mao, the Chinese Communist Party (CCP)

10 Ahmed 2004.
11 Herzfeld 2016.
12 Liao, Duan and Zhao 2023.
13 Ibid.
14 Martin and Zhou 2023; Zhou 2023.
15 For a detailed local account of the Fengqiao model's development and revival in the 1990s, see the Zhuji municipal government's "Dashiji" (Chronicle of the Fengqiao experience), https://fqjysjk.zhuji.gov.cn:8080/home/chronicle2.html.
16 Mediators are formally contracted by local governments; however, while their pay and reporting lines run through the political and legal affairs commission, their offices and mediation rooms fall under the department of social work.
17 Dickson 2016, 109.

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developed elaborate techniques to channel not just cognitive ideology but also affective knowledge forms – embodied experiences of revolutionary intensity, such as "lumps in the throat, goosebumps on the skin, or the pounding of a revolutionary heart."[18] These experiences were designed to generate political believers through emotionally charged collective rituals. This mass mobilization of emotions contrasts sharply with the present,[19] where governance targets a population disembedded from traditional community structures yet still responsive to emotional appeals.

Emotion work, or "the act of trying to change in degree or quality an emotion or feeling,"[20] was central to the CCP's revolutionary success and underpinned everything from anti-Japanese resistance to land reform campaigns.[21] Affect under Mao was overtly political and collective. The invention of "Mao-speak," for instance, created not only a lexicon but an emotional structure for expressing *class feeling* – a dual sentiment consisting of horizontal, fraternal love among the proletariat alongside intense hatred directed towards class enemies.[22] Mao's own account of political conversion, in which he trades bourgeois feeling for proletarian identification, illustrates how political subjectivity was forged through feeling, rather than ideology alone.[23]

Today's mediators are no longer revolutionary mobilizers but affect managers tasked with regulating emotion and producing administrable outcomes. Disturbances are processed through monetary settlement, documentation and procedural closure. This shift reflects what Ching Kwan Lee and Yonghong Zhang term "bureaucratic absorption," in which "officials … rely on the effects of bureaucratic procedures to buy time and reduce the visibility of unrest," demobilizing resistance rather than politicizing it.[24] These procedural effects enable an affective transformation, or "change with continuity" (*biantong*变通), in which Maoist-style thought work is reconfigured through state-led psychotherapy and traditional moral vocabularies to ease governance and optimize citizens as social resources.[25] The conversion of emotion into labour and justice into transaction thus signals a new turn in affective rule, one that manages feeling through compensation and service delivery.

The mediation room itself embodies Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of *chronotope* – a space–time configuration that structures social action. In her work on legal spaces, Mariana Valverde shows how chronotopes mediate governance by temporally delimiting permissible actions: "Penal codes act as a temporal hinge … connecting the past with the future, retribution with prevention."[26] Similarly, the mediation chronotope imposes a compressed spatio-temporality in which disputants must express, process and resolve emotional grievances, particularly volatile ones like resentment, within a single session. "The law does not make sense to someone who is worked up," Old Wang explained. "Reasoning in legal language only adds more resentment."

The mediator's task is not transformation but containment, involving the channelling of affective energy into legible, controlled expressions that meet bureaucratic expectations. This marks a shift in the state's engagement with affect: from revolutionary mobilization to professional management, from intensification to containment, from collective transformation to individualized settlement. The mediation room embodies a compressed present shaped by bureaucratic scripts, exemplifying a "present [that] is not at first an object but a mediated affect … a temporal genre whose conventions emerge from the personal and public filtering of the situations and events that are happening in an extended now."[27] Here, disruptive feelings like resentment must be resolved not across time but within the highly compressed "now" of the session.

18 Dutton 2019, 83.
19 Perry 2002; Sorace 2019.
20 Hochschild 1979, 561.
21 Perry 2002.
22 Lee, Haiyan 2019.
23 Mao in 1971, as cited in Perry 2002, 119–120.
24 Lee, Ching Kwan, and Zhang 2013, 1481; Martin and Zhou 2023.
25 Yang 2015.
26 Valverde 2015, 12.
27 Berlant 2011, 4.

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Through the purchase of mediation services, the state has transformed revolutionary mobilization into a contractual service relationship. In Andrew Kipnis's terms, this facilitates "feeling" (*ganqing* 感情) avoidance, or strategies for managing relationships without generating authentic emotional bonds.[28] *Ganqing*, the affective component of interpersonal ties, typically develops through sustained interaction and is central to *renqing* practices. In other words, good *ganqing* emerges from "the stable mutuality between people within the networks over a long period," a continuity of give-and-take that signals relational depth and authenticity.[29] Mediation disrupts this temporal logic: it enacts *renqing* through tact, empathy and emotional scripts, yet truncates the duration necessary for *ganqing* to form. Disputants do not return; relationships do not develop; the possibility of affective accumulation, vital for solidarity or resistance, is foreclosed. *Renqing* becomes aesthetic and rhetorical, stripped of affective weight.

This containment functions on three levels. First, it prevents the formation of authentic emotional bonds between the state and its contracted affective labourers. Mediators perform their duties not out of revolutionary commitment or moral obligation, but for monetary gains, around 2,000 yuan monthly plus 100 yuan per resolved case. Second, it limits *ganqing* development between disputants by prioritizing settlement over relationship repair. Third, and most critically, it ensures that no meaningful *ganqing* develops between mediators and disputants. Although the state recruits individuals with strong community ties to navigate both bureaucratic and interpersonal domains, their work becomes transactional. Mediators must draw on their embeddedness to resolve disputes, but the compensation structure renders these interactions more instrumental than expressive, resembling the calculated ties found in "interpersonal relationship" (*guanxi* 关系) networks. Each case, therefore, becomes a discrete unit of compensated labour. Some disputants even mistake mediators for police, underscoring their quasi-bureaucratic role.

This setup emphasizes a reconfiguration of prior mediation practices rather than a break from them. Traditional village mediation relied on the unpaid labour of elders whose authority stemmed from moral standing and kinship ties, while revolutionary mediation mobilized ideological fervour and class sentiment. Contemporary mediation draws affective authority from both approaches but delivers it through a service-oriented logic. In cities like A, mediation services are procured through a bidding process. To compete in the process, practitioners have established formal organizations, such as the Mediators Association. Most mediators are middle-aged men native to the area, often drawn from low-level state-affiliated roles such as court clerks, village cadres or the military, or informally selected for their local embeddedness and dialect fluency over any formal credentials. While they are required to be Party members and familiar with the law, there is no standardized training or appointment process. Their authority depends on local trust, which they must translate into state-aligned performance. This ambiguous position – contracted yet liminal, connected yet transactional – makes them ideal instruments for affective governance.

In this context, *renqing* becomes less a foundation for social life than a technology of governance.[30] Its ethical force is neutralized; its relational potential confined. Mediators perform care, but their conditions of employment ensure it remains instrumental and ultimately non-threatening. Beneath the appearance of depoliticized service provision lies a deeply political technique: absorbing social elites into the state's machinery to ensure that no one who is embedded enough to mobilize remains outside it.

This evolution mirrors broader shifts in China's affective governance under Xi Jinping, where emotional performance has become a measure of political loyalty. Xi's dictum that "All people must have grateful hearts" (*suoyou ren dou yao you gan'en de xin* 所有人都要有感恩的心) makes

28 Kipnis 2002, 28.

29 Yan 1996b, 226; Kipnis 1997.

30 Here, I draw on Nikolas Rose's (1999) concept of governmentality as the management of conduct through ethical and emotional techniques, where governance operates not only through institutions but also by shaping subjectivities.

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clear that emotional disposition is no longer merely a personal trait but a political obligation.[31] Mediation becomes a site where such affective expectations are staged. Institutional affect management signals both continuity and rupture: the state still governs through emotion, but the mode has shifted from revolutionary transformation to bureaucratic pacification. This mode of grassroots governance, according to Christian Sorace, constitutes "affective sovereignty" where "the party-state claims sovereign jurisdiction over people's emotional life" and revitalizes its authority "through its extraction of affective energy."[32] As legal meaning is increasingly negotiated through relational and moral scripts, sovereignty is enacted as much through centralization as through everyday language. Mediators act as affective brokers, performing "juris-diction," shaping legal authority through emotional labour and speech.[33]

Differential Experiences of *Renqing*: Locals, Migrants and Urban–Rural Hierarchies

While *renqing* serves as the ethical substrate of mediation in contemporary China, its operation is far from egalitarian. Culturally and bureaucratically, it functions as a differentiated mode of incorporation, selectively extending affective recognition along existing social hierarchies, including distinctions between long-term residents and migrants, as well as gendered and urban–rural divides. As Yunxiang Yan observes, in rural China, *guanxi* networks constitute a "local moral" world wherein *renqing* provides the governing ethics, fusing obligation, emotional attachment, reciprocal recognition and, in their extended form, exchangeable resources and instrumental relations.[34] In A city, claims to *renqing* depend not only on shared cultural norms of reciprocity but also on proximity, including linguistic, geographic and genealogical ties.

State actors attempt to formalize *renqing* as a governance tool, but its circulation reveals an "affective economy," where emotions "stick" to some bodies more easily than others, granting moral weight to certain claims while rendering others unintelligible.[35] Locals whose dialect, kinship ties and community embeddedness align with institutional expectations are more likely to have their emotions read as authentic and culturally appropriate. But for those positioned outside these normative frameworks – migrants, women and residents from less prestigious rural areas – *renqing* is often withheld or redirected as a disciplinary tool. Their emotional expressions may be misrecognized as defiance or ingratitude, while their failure to conform to dominant scripts marks them as morally suspect or socially out of place.

This stratified affective logic parallels what Aihwa Ong terms "graduated sovereignty," a flexible configuration of state power that governs different populations and spaces according to their perceived value to the broader political or economic project.[36] While Ong developed this concept in the context of South-East Asia, similar dynamics operate within China's mediation system. Here, affective recognition is shaped not by fixed categories but by one's social position within intersecting hierarchies of urbanity, gender and local belonging. While *renqing* presents itself as a shared moral ground, its deployment by mediators often reinforces existing hierarchies. It adheres most readily to those whose identities conform to local norms of propriety, while those at the intersection of migrant status and gender, especially young migrant women, are often treated as problems to be contained or corrected. In this way, the bureaucratization of *renqing* produces a form of "inclusive exclusion" – it incorporates subjects into institutional processes while simultaneously reaffirming

31 Sorace 2021, 29.
32 Sorace 2019, 150.
33 Richland (2013) conceptualizes *juris-diction* as the enactment of law's authority through language. Pia (2020) similarly describes Chinese mediation as "jurisprudential massage," where affective performances reconfigure legal meaning and state power.
34 Yan 1996b.
35 Ahmed 2004.
36 Ong 2000.

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their marginality.[37] The result is a governance technology that sustains affective inequality under the guise of cultural continuity.

Although the institutionalization of mediation has transformed conflict resolution, the cultural specificity of emotional expression endures. *Renqing* continues to function as a moral system regulating interactions across both informal and bureaucratic contexts. Within the mediation room, these cultural patterns form what I term an *affective grammar*: a system that governs how emotions are expressed, by whom and with what social consequences. This formulation resonates with Axel Honneth's understanding of the "grammar" of social struggles as fundamentally moral, rooted in the intersubjective conditions for self-realization.[38] For Honneth, "the feelings of outrage and indignation driving [social struggles] are generated by the rejection of claims to recognition and thus imply normative judgements about the legitimacy of social arrangements."[39] Yet in Chinese police mediation, this affective grammar is not grounded in mutual recognition but in a stratified logic of legitimacy that privileges certain emotional claims over others. Building on approaches that treat emotion as socially managed,[40] shaped by expressive regimes,[41] and circulated to reinforce collective boundaries,[42] I trace how *renqing* structures affective expression while reinforcing hierarchies of inclusion and exclusion.

This grammar becomes visible through ritual practices that structure mediation from the outset. Mediators routinely open sessions with the seemingly casual question, "Where are you from?" While administrative records already contain this information, the verbal inquiry allows for real-time affective calibration, establishing commonality or difference before any discussion of the case. Language choice is also central. In A city, with its four local dialects, mediators selectively code-switch to establish rapport with locals, often ensuring that "private" consultations occur out of earshot. By contrast, when one party is a migrant and the other a local, mediators frequently hold these conversations in front of both parties, creating informational asymmetries that favour those who share the dialect or understand the local context.

Embodied rituals likewise encode *renqing* into gendered hierarchies. Offering a cigarette, a common ritual in the mediation room, circulates almost exclusively among men. Although I identify as non-binary, I was consistently perceived as a woman in these settings and was therefore limited to a respectful verbal greeting and excluded from these exchanges. During my entire fieldwork, I was offered a cigarette only once. Notably, it occurred when I was temporarily positioned as "part of the team," not as a woman. These bodily interactions reveal how *renqing*, far from reflecting spontaneous emotional connection, operates through gendered scripts that facilitate strategic bonds while reinforcing normative exclusions.

Even the temporal structure of mediation – presentation of accounts, private consultation, negotiation and agreement – imposes a sequential grammar on emotion. Specific emotional responses are expected at each stage: indignation or sorrow during accounts, receptivity in consultation, compromise in negotiation, and closure, satisfaction or resignation at agreement. Yet these expectations are unevenly applied. Mediators often structure the space asymmetrically, instructing one party to "speak" while telling the other to "listen quietly," a dynamic that manages emotional pacing while signalling whose voice holds moral legitimacy. These patterns are repeated throughout mediation: disputants' affective expression is permitted or restricted not only by the procedural stage but also by how their social identity aligns with local norms and the mediator's authority. Emotional disruptions to this sequencing are rarely accommodated and are often read as resistance rather than legitimate affective response.

37 Cho 2013.
38 Honneth 1995.
39 Anderson 1995, xii.
40 Hochschild 1979.
41 Reddy 2001; Clarke 2019.
42 Ahmed 2004.

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These affective scripts take on different meanings, depending on who enters the mediation room. For local residents embedded in community networks, mediators draw on shared norms to encourage resolution. Consider Little Chen and Little Li, a married couple whose dispute centred on the husband's drunken assault on his father-in-law. When Little Li approached Old Wang, she engaged in "speaking bitterness" (*suku* 诉苦), a Maoist-era performative script once used to mobilize class resentment and moral authority through expressions of suffering.[43] Although distinct from truth-telling, *suku* centres on "constructing one's own version of truth" through emotionally resonant appeals.[44] By invoking "swallowing bitterness" (*chiku* 吃苦) and returning to her natal home, Little Li situated herself within a familiar affective grammar of female endurance. Her distress, although culturally legible, did not elicit empathy or protection.

Old Wang responded with sympathy and deflection: "It's unfortunate this handsome young man becomes a monster when he drinks. But as mediators, we always 'encourage reconciliation over separation' (*quanhe buquanfen* 劝和不劝分). Think about the *ganqing* you share!" By framing marriage as a container for *ganqing*, a relational bond presumed to hold enduring value, Old Wang reinterpreted her suffering as evidence of relational depth, not harm. The mediation script required her to perform injury in a legible way, only to have that performance reabsorbed into a normative structure of forgiveness and family preservation. This case shows how *renqing*'s affective grammar legitimates women's emotional expression only when performed within relational duty and restraint, recognizing it not as a claim to protection or accountability but as a gesture towards reconciliation.

This redirection of emotion into a script of familial endurance reflects broader patterns in Chinese kinship and social organization. As Fei Xiaotong notes, traditional family structures prioritize stability over affective connection, suppressing what he calls "ordinary emotions" like spontaneous affection, anger or distress.[45] Within these hierarchies, emotional legitimacy is uneven: men are permitted volatility, while women are expected to manage their feelings to preserve relational order.

Traditional kinship and family relations, which are organized around generational rank, age and gender, set moral expectations and shape emotional conduct.[46] The mediation room reproduces these hierarchies, as seen in Old Wang's framing of forgiveness as women's moral duty. When an auxiliary officer later joked to Little Chen, "You shouldn't come here so often," he invoked a masculine script of understanding, at the expense of accountability. This homosocial alignment was reinforced when Old Wang offered Little Chen a redemption narrative, while Little Li was expected to absorb harm "for the sake of the child." The interaction exemplifies how affective grammar is unevenly distributed: men's transgressions are contextualized within narratives of repair, while women's suffering is folded into scripts of reconciliation and endurance. Despite shedding revolutionary connotations, techniques such as "speaking bitterness" continue to follow gendered patterns: women's affective labour remains vital to social reproduction yet devalued in public discourse.[47]

For migrants excluded from local networks, the affective grammar of *renqing* often functions as a structure of illegibility. In one mediation session, a dispute between a local man and an unhoused, non-local migrant escalated into physical violence. The migrant repeatedly stated only one thing: "I'm hurt, I need to see a doctor." Yet instead of responding to his claim as a legitimate expression of pain, both the mediator and the police officers framed him as "insane" (*shenjingbing* 神经病), a colloquial term here deployed to undermine his credibility. Throughout the session, the local and Old Wang spoke in the regional dialect, which the migrant could not understand, creating not only a linguistic exclusion but also an affective one. Unable to participate in the shared affective grammar that dialect embodies, the migrant remained physically present but affectively sidelined, his claims neither taken seriously nor granted moral weight.

43 Perry 2002; Yang 2013.
44 Martin and Zhou 2023, 149.
45 Fei 1992.
46 Ibid; Yan 2015; Kipnis 1997.
47 Hershatter 2007.

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Even after receiving medical treatment, the resolution was framed not in moral terms but as "bad luck" (*daomei* 倒霉), a narrative that displaced accountability and reaffirmed the migrant's status as a source of inconvenience over injury. In this context, *renqing* does not circulate to generate empathy but rather to enforce emotional boundaries. The migrant's repeated expression, "I'm hurt," failed to activate the affective script required to receive recognition: no apology, no shared dialect, no moral positioning. Again, as Sara Ahmed reminds us, affect "sticks" to certain bodies in ways that mark them as threats or burdens.[48] Here, the *sticky* associations of mobility, poverty and mental health attached to the migrant, rendering his pain suspect and his presence socially volatile. The affective grammar of mediation thus became a mechanism of containment – not to facilitate relational repair but to process emotional illegibility into administrative closure.

For migrants, then, *renqing* becomes not a resource for inclusion but a structure of exclusion – either withheld or instrumentalized as a disciplinary tool. Rather than fostering empathy, it is invoked to highlight their vulnerability and to reaffirm their distance from local moral worlds. This differential interpretation reveals the central paradox of China's managed individualization: the state promotes mobility while simultaneously withdrawing the welfare protections that once accompanied collective belonging, leaving migrants "forced to fall back on the family and personal network or *guanxi*."[49] Yet these networks are often unavailable or inaccessible to migrants, especially in conflict situations. As a result, migrants are subject to mediation processes that demand emotional performances they cannot authentically provide, such as scripts of remorse, gratitude or shared affiliation that presuppose the very forms of social embeddedness from which they have been structurally severed.

The affective grammar of *renqing* also calibrates emotional value upwards, privileging those whose social status aligns with the mediator's aspirational or strategic interests. In one traffic accident case, a local scooter owner faced a woman from Hangzhou, the provincial capital, whose car had badly damaged his vehicle. During mediation, the local man sat quietly while the mediator focused almost entirely on the woman. Their conversation, conducted in Mandarin instead of the local dialect, centred not on the accident but on her life in Hangzhou, her property purchases and the mediator's son, who also lived there. These exchanges followed a script of aspirational affiliation, positioning *renqing* as a tool for networking and upwards identification. Eventually, the mediator urged the local man to accept a settlement of just 300 yuan, telling him he should be "grateful" not to have been injured. *Renqing* was present but unequally distributed: the woman received empathy and formed an informal rapport with the mediator, while the man was cast into a script of stoic acceptance and discouraged from expressing grievance, reinforcing a deferential posture within the mediation hierarchy.

The Hangzhou woman's urban status granted her conversational privilege and structured the entire affective framing of the dispute. In a city like A, situated mid-tier in China's developmental hierarchy, mediators often treat visitors from more prestigious urban centres as socially valuable. Her ease in the room contrasted sharply with the local man's marginality. The mediator framed the local man's material loss as insignificant in light of his "good luck" at avoiding injury, even though the scooter had been completely written off and 300 yuan fell far short of its value. These affective preferences align with a grassroots governance model increasingly shaped by performance and accountability. As mediation becomes a contracted service, mediators manage emotional effort strategically, offering *renqing* where it promises social or institutional return. The mediation room functions simultaneously as a site of conflict resolution and a space where affective value is unevenly distributed according to urban privilege.

Gender further compounds the marginalization of migrants in mediation spaces. When teenage migrant girls were brought into the station, wearing revealing clothing and displaying tattoos, officers

48 Ahmed 2004.
49 Yan 2020, 289.

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assumed surrogate patriarchal roles. One remarked, "If I were your dad and saw you like this, I'd break your damn leg," asserting paternal authority that regulated behaviour through control over appearance and sexual propriety. This paternalism, framed through the language of *renqing*, mobilized traditional gender norms to regulate young women deemed morally deviant, showing how state authority operates through the sexualized control of female bodies.

Female mobility in China has long been governed by tightly regulated pathways, primarily through marriage arrangements between natal and marital families.[50] Women's movement outside these channels has been viewed as threatening to social order. Young migrant women thus occupy a precarious position, which is compounded by stereotypes of rural women in urban spaces. Often labelled as "third parties" (*di sanzhe* 第三者), or mistresses threatening family stability, they are confronted with "surveillance and control over their behaviors and bodies" as well as gossip that damages their reputation and future prospects.[51] The officers' reaction to the tattooed teenagers illustrates how state actors invoke patriarchal authority to regulate female autonomy, especially when self-expression shaped by market-oriented individualism appears to challenge the moral norms that bind female respectability to family discipline and reproductive order.

For the young women, who were outside of both home and local networks, the officers' paternal language functioned not merely as discipline but as affective intervention, seeking to reattach "unbound" bodies to normative kinship roles and moral expectations. Emotions work to align bodies with social norms, "creating the very effect of the surfaces or boundaries of bodies and worlds" and shaping not only what is felt but who is permitted to feel it.[52] In this context, the figure of the unattached young woman becomes a site of moral anxiety, her visibility prompting improvised fatherly authority aimed at restoring familial control where kinship ties are absent. These young women were granted no emotional subjectivity of their own.

This gendered approach to affective governance was further reinforced when officers, before releasing them, instructed the much older local man accompanying them to "look after them," transferring supervisory responsibility without acknowledging the power dynamics of the relationship. While male migrants may be marginalized through economic or legal means, female migrants are subject to affective and moral containment, governed through scripts that conflate care with control and autonomy with divergence.

Far from serving as a universal moral framework, *renqing* emerges across these cases as a stratifying mechanism calibrated to social position. In the mediation room, what appears as a culturally familiar practice functions as "cultural intimacy" – an affective space where normative gestures conceal power's reproduction.[53] This dynamic reflects the Fengqiao model's transformation from revolutionary mobilization to outsourced affective labour, with professional mediators deploying culturally resonant scripts to manage disputes while preserving hierarchies. The state's embrace of *renqing*-based mediation acknowledges that bureaucratic procedures alone cannot resolve conflicts rooted in inequality. Yet by outsourcing affective labour to actors embedded in these same structures, mediation often reproduces the very exclusions it seeks to resolve. By repackaging *renqing* as tradition, the state governs through intimacy while maintaining the appearance of moral neutrality.

Resistance Within the Mediation Room: The Limits of Affective Governance

If *renqing* operates as an affective grammar, structuring who can express which emotions, when and in what form, then resistance often takes shape as misalignment with these emotional expectations. While police mediation mandates physical presence, compulsion extends only to the body, not emotional participation. Within the chronotope of the mediation room, a bounded space–time shaping

50 Judd 2002; Stafford 2008.
51 Gaetano 2015, 119.
52 Ahmed 2004, 117.
53 Herzfeld 2016.

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social action, what unfolds is shaped not only by institutional scripts but also by participants' affective choices. In a system reliant on calibrated performances such as remorse, gratitude and receptivity, some participants resist incorporation into the moral order of *renqing*.

Drawing on William Reddy's concept of emotional regimes as normative structures that define which feelings are appropriate, legible and politically safe, I develop *affective autonomy* to describe how participants, especially those excluded from local networks, refuse to align with expected emotional scripts.[54] These refusals often take subtle and strategic forms – silence, withdrawal, non-recognition or engaging alternative affective registers – paralleling what James Scott calls "weapons of the weak."[55] As Saba Mahmood has shown, autonomy need not imply liberal self-possession but can emerge through affective constraint, embedded in "the grammar of concepts within which it resides": the institutional and semantic structures making possible particular ways of relating to people, norms and the self.[56] Rather than expressing remorse, gratitude or reciprocity in the *renqing*-based grammar of mediation, some participants withhold emotional participation or cultivate alternative alignments. These refusals may not register as resistance in a conventional sense, but they destabilize the emotional regime by interrupting the circuits through which emotions acquire social and political force via repetition and attachment.[57] By resisting emotional incorporation, participants reveal the limits of affective governance: emotions may be channelled but not fully contained.

These forms of affective autonomy manifest through diverse strategies across different populations in the mediation room. The migrant workers' case exemplifies withdrawal as a form of autonomy. Brought to the station after a late-night altercation, both men maintained rigid postures throughout their session, refusing eye contact with either Old Wang or each other. When the mediator attempted to establish common ground by noting that they came from neighbouring villages in the same province, neither acknowledged this connection, effectively rejecting the manufactured solidarity based on shared outsider status. Their responses were limited to monosyllabic utterances or complete silence.

After an entire morning of attempted engagement, one individual requested administrative detention, choosing formal punishment over participation in a mediation system that held little emotional resonance for him. In doing so, he refused both the moral obligations embedded in *renqing*-based mediation and the affective grammar through which the Fengqiao model enacts governance at the grassroots level. These refusals highlight a disalignment from the emotional regime that governs mediation, where expressions of remorse or gratitude are expected to reaffirm normative attachments.[58]

The refusal to perform the expected emotional scripts directly challenges the institutional management of affective labour described earlier. While mediation has been reconfigured from revolutionary mobilization into contracted governance, its effectiveness still hinges on participants' willingness to engage emotionally. When migrants choose silence over participation, they expose a central contradiction in the commodification of affective labour: emotional resonance cannot be compelled, and scripts based on local *renqing* logics are not universal. These refusals force mediators to confront the limits of governance strategies that rely on emotionally persuasive authority, particularly when applied to individuals severed from traditional networks of obligation.

Such affective autonomy presents practical challenges to the mediation system's internal logic. When participants remain disengaged, officers face a bureaucratic dilemma: unresolved disputes risk escalating up the administrative hierarchy, drawing scrutiny from superiors and undermining performance evaluations. Strategic non-participation thus pressures mediators to choose between prolonging ineffective negotiations or converting cases into formal administrative punishment – an

54 Reddy 2001.
55 Scott 1985.
56 Mahmood 2005, 34.
57 Ahmed 2004.
58 Reddy 2001.

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outcome that contradicts the Fengqiao model's foundational promise to "resolve minor matters at the grassroots" without burdening higher levels of governance.[59] These dynamics are well documented in studies of bureaucratic anxiety and risk aversion in local governance systems, where officials strive to avoid "trouble" that could threaten stability targets.[60]

Yet not all resistance takes the form of silence or withdrawal. As seen earlier with the tattooed teenage girls, affective autonomy may also involve the creation of parallel emotional worlds within the visible space of mediation. While they outwardly complied with officers' paternal disciplining by nodding at advice and avoiding confrontation, they also exchanged whispers, stifled laughter and shared glances, cultivating an intimate affective space that remained inappropriate yet unintelligible to institutional authority. These performances did not openly defy gendered scripts but rather mobilized them strategically; the appearance of innocence, deference or emotional pliability served as camouflage for quiet affective refusal.

Feminist scholars have long noted that women navigate patriarchal structures through open resistance and calculated compliance, adopting seemingly naïve or obedient roles to deflect attention, avoid punishment or pursue alternative goals.[61] What appears as acquiescence may in fact be a tactical inhabiting of normative femininity. This aligns with work on situated knowledge in feminist epistemology, which emphasizes how marginalized subjects develop subtle, embodied strategies for manoeuvring within systems of control.[62] In this case, affective autonomy emerges as much through the careful modulation of emotional expression as through the avoidance of direct refusal, allowing for relational solidarity while minimizing institutional intervention.

The officers' closing gesture of assigning responsibility for the young women to a much older man, without addressing the power imbalance, further underscores the patriarchal logic underpinning *renqing*-based mediation. This moment functioned to reaffirm heteronormative norms of male guardianship while rendering the emotional agency of the young women illegible. Yet within that illegibility, these women cultivated a space of mutual recognition and autonomy. Their resistance was not against discipline per se but against the "regularities of capture," the "structures of oppression" that draw power not from coercion but from "feeding off the energies of collective life," despite having "no motive force of [their] own."[63] This parasitic logic depends on capturing and redirecting affective energies.

Additionally, affective autonomy can also involve the deliberate amplification of emotional expression, turning affect into a resource for political negotiation. When Old Ding's family staged daily silent protests, publicly displaying his portrait at the construction site where he died, they transformed private grief into a visibly politicized force. Their actions blurred the line between mourning and dissent, creating an emotionally charged atmosphere that exceeded the procedural logic of the legal-mediation system. Unlike the migrant workers' withdrawal or the teenage girls' creation of a parallel affective world, this strategy centred on emotional visibility: a form of "grief work" that, through its intensity, demanded recognition and compensation without relying on compliance. Grief thus becomes "a resource for politics" when it forces institutions to reckon with forms of loss that do not fit neatly within established regimes of intelligibility.[64]

In this case, the family's sustained public mourning, which was initially dismissed as excessive or disruptive, ultimately secured an increased compensation package, rising from an initial 100,000 yuan to 250,000 yuan following police involvement. Their strategic display of loss mobilized affect in a way that exceeded containment, exposing how institutional anxieties about maintaining social stability can be leveraged from below. Within this mode, affective autonomy is exercised through

59 Liao, Duan and Zhao 2023; Martin and Zhou 2023.
60 Heilmann and Perry 2011; Lee, Ching Kwan, and Zhang 2013.
61 Pateman 1988; Wolf 1990.
62 Haraway 1988.
63 Massumi 2015, 102.
64 Butler 2006, 30.

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emotionally saturated presence, an assertion of moral legitimacy that reframes grief as both relational and confrontational.

Together, these cases illuminate how affective autonomy functions as a multi-dimensional form of resistance within the structures of China's grassroots governance in the context of frontline policing. Whether through withdrawal, the creation of parallel emotional spaces or the strategic amplification of grief, mediation participants engage affect not simply as expression but as a mode of negotiation, refusal and world-making. These practices do not necessarily reject the moral logics of *renqing*-based governance outright; however, they reconfigure the affective terms on which incorporation is accepted, deferred or denied. In doing so, they expose the fragility of a governance technology that depends on the legibility and management of *renqing* to secure social order. Yet affective life is never fully capturable by institutional scripts; it leaks, distorts and exceeds.[65] Affective autonomy thus exposes the limits of governance by making visible the minor, relational and often gendered ways individuals reclaim the capacity to feel otherwise, even within tightly managed spaces.

Conclusion

Returning to the mediation room where we began, Old Wang's handling of the privacy violation case illuminates a central tension in Chinese grassroots policing: the gap between formal legal procedures and the affective dimensions of justice that citizens often seek. His remark that "the law has no *renqingwei*" encapsulates the transformation of policing into a negotiation between bureaucratic objectives and local moral expectations. By channelling an administrative violation into a negotiated settlement with direct compensation, Old Wang enacted *renqing* as an "idiom of grassroots social vitality" through which policing actually happens.[66] This moment exemplifies the affective grammar explored throughout the article: a system of emotional expression and recognition within police mediation that regulates not just how disputes are processed but which emotional claims are deemed legitimate.

The evolution of the Fengqiao model reflects a shift in how the state engages affect at the grassroots. The revolutionary mobilization that once relied on "emotional energy for revolutionary purposes" has given way to containment managed through contractual service provision.[67] In the mediation room, feelings are no longer mobilized to build class solidarity but are instead managed through "bureaucratic absorption" that delays resolution and obscures social unrest.[68] In doing so, the state converts volatile emotions such as resentment into administratively legible and manageable outcomes.

The institutionalization of mediation creates distinctly uneven experiences across populations. While local residents embedded in community networks often benefit from affective scripts that facilitate resolution, individuals marginalized by intersecting factors such as gender, migration status and class background are more often positioned as risks to be contained. In contrast to formal legal rationality, emotions circulate in "an economy of affect," where they "stick" to particular figures and create "the very effect of a collective."[69] Within the mediation room, this dynamic mirrors "graduated sovereignty," a biopolitical logic that applies "differential state treatment of segments of the population in relation to market calculations."[70] Yet even here, emotional life resists full capture. Practices of affective autonomy, ranging from strategic silence to the cultivation of alternate emotional registers, create frictions within the affective scripts mediators attempt to enforce. These moments resonate with "forms of resistance that stop well short of collective outright defiance,"

65 Ahmed 2004; Berlant 2011.
66 Martin 2019, 43.
67 Li 1942, as cited in Perry 2002, 112.
68 Lee, Ching Kwan, and Zhang 2013; Martin and Zhou 2023.
69 Ahmed 2004, 119.
70 Ong 2000, 57.

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yet nonetheless disrupt state projects of social ordering,[71] echoing the logics of "rightful resistance" that leverage official rhetoric to push back from within,[72] or what Diana Fu describes as "mobilizing without the masses," where dispersed, low-profile acts nonetheless challenge state control.[73] While physical presence in the mediation room can be mandated, emotional participation cannot.

Attempts to manage affect through *renqing*-based mediation signal a broader exercise of "affective sovereignty," in which the party-state asserts control over emotional life and reinforces its authority by drawing on and redirecting affective energies.[74] This claim, however, is never fully realized. The outsourcing of emotional governance to contracted mediators acknowledges the limits of bureaucratic authority and the inadequacy of legal rationality. Yet the system reinscribes social hierarchies: *renqing* becomes a differentiated mode of incorporation in which, to borrow Fei's terms, "your pains and sorrows are interconnected" only with those in your most intimate, familial circles.[75]

Rather than relying solely on coercion or legality, Chinese grassroots governance and frontline policing increasingly operate through "machinery to channel 'affective' knowledge forms."[76] Mediators occupy a hybrid position, enacting culturally familiar care while advancing the state's stability agenda. Yet affect is never fully containable. It moves through bodies in ways that exceed institutional scripts, producing ruptures that state actors struggle to anticipate or reabsorb. As a mode of governance, affect is reactive and improvisational. In this sense, structures of power are defined as much by what escapes them as by what they contain. They are "always running after different-order movements in the collective field of embodied activity in order to funnel them back into their own channels."[77] The state may regulate the performance of emotion, but it cannot monopolize its force.

Renqing thus functions as a political grammar of emotion in police mediation. Its institutionalization stratifies affective legitimacy, while moments of affective autonomy emerge within and against these scripts. Ultimately, the use of *renqing* in mediation reflects a post-reform governance strategy that deploys cultural tradition through contractual and performance-based mechanisms to maintain political order. Yet this very process creates affective residues and slippages – spaces where refusal, solidarity and mourning produce new relational possibilities. These practices lay bare the affective demands of contemporary policing – and their limits. In the mediation room, what appears as tradition is often a mechanism of control. But what appears as compliance can also be resistance. And where the state seeks to govern feeling, feeling does not always comply.

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71 Scott 1985, 29.
72 O'Brien and Li 2006.
73 Fu 2017.
74 Sorace 2019.
75 Fei 1992, 124.
76 Dutton 2019, 83.
77 Massumi 2015, 102.

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